with the oft-flickering thought that has been credited to Amazon’s Jeff Bezos: “Your fat margins are my opportunity.”[8]

If financial incumbents don’t embrace the technology themselves, Bitcoin and blockchain technology could do to banks what cell phones did to telephone poles. Nearly every global bank, exchange, custodian, and financial services provider is part of some blockchain consortium, investing in the potential disruptors or internally building its own team. These players include JP Morgan, Goldman Sachs, Citibank, the New York Stock Exchange, NASDAQ, Banco Santander, Barclays, UBS, South African Reserve Bank, Bank of Tokyo Mitsubishi, Mizuho, China Merchants Bank, Australian Stock Exchange, and more.

Financial incumbents are aware blockchain technology puts on the horizon a world without cash—no need for loose bills, brick-and-mortar banks, or, potentially, centralized monetary policies. Instead, value is handled virtually, through a system that has no central authority figure and is governed in a decentralized and democratic manner. Mathematics force order in the operations. Our life savings, and that of our heirs, could be entirely intangible, floating in a soup of secure 1s and 0s, the entire system accessed through computers and smartphones.

Technology providers smell the disruption as well, with Microsoft and IBM most vocally leading the charge. Microsoft provides Blockchain as a Service (BaaS) for developers within its Azure cloud platform. Marley Gray, its director of technology strategy, has said, “We want, and frankly our